

Learning and Development Policy

Version 1.0 | Owner: People Operations | Effective 2026-01-01 | Next review 2027-01-01

1. Purpose

Zuqah Technologies invests in its people. This policy describes the learning budget available to every employee, how to access it, what it covers and what is expected in return.

2. Learning budget

Every permanent employee receives an annual learning budget from their first working day.

Level	Annual budget
Individual Contributor	■25,000 per year
Senior / Lead	■40,000 per year
Manager	■50,000 per year

Budgets are calculated per financial year (April–March) and do not carry over to the following year. Contract and part-time employees are eligible on a pro-rated basis.

3. What the budget can be used for

3.1 Covered

- Online courses and platforms (Coursera, Udemy, LinkedIn Learning, Pluralsight, A Cloud Guru, etc.)

- Technical certifications (AWS, Azure, GCP, CKAD, PMP, etc.)
- Professional certification exam fees and preparation materials
- Books (digital or physical) directly related to the role
- Technical workshops and bootcamps
- Conference attendance (see section 4)

3.2 Not covered

- Degree programmes (see section 5 for special arrangements)
- Courses that are purely personal and have no connection to the current role or a plausible next role at Zuqah Technologies

- Equipment (laptops, monitors, peripherals) — see the Hardware Refresh Policy
- Courses already mandated and paid for by Zuqah Technologies (POSH training,

security awareness, etc.)

If in doubt about whether something qualifies, ask People Operations before purchasing.

4. Conference attendance

4.1 Within learning budget

A single conference may be funded from the learning budget if the registration fee falls within the remaining budget.

4.2 Additional budget for conferences

Where the conference fee plus travel and accommodation would exceed the learning budget, the employee may request additional funding from People Operations. Approval is at the manager's discretion, subject to team budget availability.

4.3 What is expected

Employees who attend a conference are expected to share at least one key takeaway with the team — a short talk, a written summary or a demo — within two weeks of returning.

5. Degree programmes and long-form study

Zuqah Technologies may support employees pursuing part-time postgraduate degrees (MBA, M.Tech, executive programmes) that are directly relevant to their role and career at the company. Support may include:

- Partial or full funding (agreed case by case)
- Study leave of up to 5 days per year during exam periods
- Flexible working hours during intensive modules, by agreement with the manager

Degree programme support requires approval from the employee's manager and the CEO, and a written agreement on any repayment conditions if the employee leaves within 24 months of receiving the benefit.

6. How to request learning

6.1 Courses and certifications (within budget)

- 1. Discuss the learning goal with your manager to confirm it aligns with your development plan
- 2. Log in to the HR portal → Learning → Request Learning
- 3. Fill in the course name, provider, cost and expected completion date
- 4. Submit — your manager will approve or decline within 3 working days
- 5. Once approved, purchase the course and submit the invoice for reimbursement through the expense system, or request a purchase order if paying directly

6.2 Reimbursement

Submit the receipt through the Expense and Travel Policy process within 30 days of purchase. Code the expense as "Learning and Development."

6.3 Courses not requiring prior approval

Purchases of ■2,000 or less per item (e.g., a single book or a low-cost online course) may be purchased and expensed without prior approval, provided they fall within the annual budget.

7. Certification exam support

7.1 First attempt

The cost of a certification exam (e.g., AWS Solutions Architect, Microsoft Azure Fundamentals) is covered by the learning budget with manager approval.

7.2 Retakes

A single retake is covered if the first attempt was unsuccessful. A second retake requires manager approval and a note on what additional preparation has been done.

7.3 Time to prepare

Employees may use up to 2 working days of study leave per certification attempt, to be agreed in advance with the manager. Study leave is in addition to the learning budget and is paid.

8. Internal learning

In addition to the individual budget, Zuqah Technologies provides:

- Internal knowledge-sharing sessions (Lunch & Learn, tech talks)
- Peer mentoring — employees may request to be paired with a more senior colleague for structured mentoring
- Manager training for all people managers, provided by the company
- Onboarding programme for new starters (see Onboarding Policy)

Participation in internal sessions does not count against the learning budget.

9. Learning and performance reviews

Learning goals are discussed at the beginning of each performance cycle and reviewed at the mid-year check-in and annual review. Actively pursuing development is a positive indicator in performance conversations.

10. If you leave Zuqah Technologies

10.1 Certifications

Certifications are yours — they go with you. Zuqah Technologies does not ask for repayment of certification costs on resignation.

10.2 Degree programmes

If an employee leaves Zuqah Technologies within 24 months of receiving degree programme funding of more than ■50,000, a pro-rated repayment applies as agreed in the support letter signed at the time of the award.

10.3 Unused budget

Unused learning budget cannot be paid out on departure.

Sample content for demonstration purposes. Zuqah Technologies is a fictional company and this document describes no real organisation's policy.